PPPE 6310, Assignment 3: Proposing a New Measure

1. **Which program or organization would you like to make this suggestion to?**
    - I would propose this measure for the World Values Survey (WVS), which will serve as a main secondary dataset for the study, providing cross-national data on religion, political behavior, and governance, making it appropriate for analyzing perceptions of religious influence on political-decision making. Related measures such as the Pew Research Center, the International Social Survey Program (ISSP), the Religion and State (RAS) Project at Bar-Ilan University, and the Association of Religion Data Archives will be used for support, because each contains measures related to religion, politics, and the relationship between religion and government (Haerpfer et al., 2022; Rotolo & Smith, 2026; ISSP Research Group, 2020; Fox, 2019; Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.).

2. **What is the measure or question you are proposing?**
    - Instead of "How long does religion's political influence last within a society?", the research question will be more flexible and give respondents more options. My research question will ask, "To what extent do individuals believe that religion continues to influence political-decision making in a society?" This will allow for numerous answers, supported by research and survey data for each individual.

3. **Who is the target population?**
    - The target population is the general adult population across countries and societies. The question should not be restricted to researchers or statisticians because the measure is designed to capture ordinary individuals' perception of religion's political influence.

4. **What response options will respondents have?**
    - Individuals would answer using a five-point scale: No influence at all, Slight influence, Moderate influence, Strong influence, or Very strong influence.

5. **Has this measure been psychometrically tested or validated?**
    - This measure has not yet been psychometrically tested or validated. Research and datasets from the WVS, Pew Research Center, ISSP, RAS, and ARDA support the existing measures of religious influence on politics, but the question itself requires psychometric testing and validation (Haerpfer et al., 2022; Rotolo & Smith, 2026; ISSP Research Group, 2020; Fox, 2019; Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.).

6. **What assumptions are embedded in the measure?**

- One of the assumptions embedded in the measure is that religion is politically relevant in a nation/society where individuals evaluate its influence on political-decision making. Iran, an Islamic theocracy, views religion as highly influential in its society based on Sharia law. The United States views religion as somewhat influential through elections and political parties. In France, individuals may perceive religion as being limited within their political society (Fox, 2019). Another assumption is that individuals are aware enough of their political system to accurately analyze religion's influence on political decision-making. In many Western European countries and the United States, where religion may be less connected to and visible in government institutions, individuals may need to evaluate its influence through elections, political parties, and debates, rather than assuming there's little to no religious influence. The measure is more likely to overestimate religious influence because respondents with strong religious or secular views may interpret political phenomena through their existing beliefs about religion even when other factors are involved.

7. **What sources of reporting bias might affect this measure?**
   - Five reporting biases might affect this measure. First, social desirability bias may affect this measure because individuals may underestimate or overestimate religion's influence depending on its social acceptability in their society. Second, confirmation bias may affect the measure, as respondents may interpret political events in ways that reinforce what they already believe about religion and politics. Third, political knowledge bias may cause respondents with less political knowledge to misjudge or misunderstand religion's influence on political decisions. Fourth is nonresponse bias, where individuals with strong religious or secular perspectives may be less willing to answer the question. Last is cultural or ideological interpretation bias, where individuals in different societies may view "religion" and "political influence" differently.

8. **How would your proposed measure improve upon existing approaches?**
   - The proposed measure will improve on existing approaches by directly measuring individuals' perceptions of how much religion influences political decision-making. Existing datasets often measure religiosity, support for religious involvement in politics, or institutional relationships between religion and the state, but they do not always directly measure perceived political influence. Additionally, the measure could capture perspectives from individuals in secular or religiously diverse societies whose perspectives are not fully demonstrated by individual measures of religion and government (Haerpfer et al., 2022; Rotolo & Smith, 2026; ISSP Research Group, 2020; Fox, 2019; Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.). This question would allow researchers to compare

perceptions across countries and identify where religious influence is viewed as strong, limited, or absent.

References

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